English Writing (EW)

Comprehensive Study Guide

Expository Writing, Essays, Reports, Plagiarism,
7 C's of Communication & 100 Ways to Improve Writing

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"Good writing is clear thinking made visible."

Exam Preparation Document

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1 Introduction to Expository Writing

What is Expository Writing?

Expository writing is a type of writing that aims to **explain, inform, describe, or define** a subject to the reader. It is fact-based, objective, and does **not** include the writer's personal opinions or emotions. The word "expository" comes from the Latin *exponere*, meaning "to put forth" or "to explain."

1.1 Key Characteristics

1. **Informative & Factual** – Presents verified information, data, and evidence rather than personal feelings.
2. **Objective Tone** – The writer maintains a neutral, third-person perspective (no "I think" or "I feel").
3. **Clear & Logical Organization** – Ideas flow in a structured, coherent manner using transitions.
4. **Thesis-Driven** – A clear thesis statement guides the entire piece.
5. **Evidence-Based** – Claims are supported with facts, statistics, examples, and expert opinions.
6. **Formal Language** – Avoids slang, colloquialisms, and emotional language.

1.2 Types of Expository Writing

Type	Purpose	Example
Descriptive	Describes a topic using facts and details	An article describing how the solar system works
Process / How-to	Explains step-by-step procedures	A recipe; "How to change a tire"
Compare & Contrast	Shows similarities and differences between two subjects	Comparing online vs. traditional education
Cause & Effect	Explains why something happens and its results	Effects of deforestation on climate
Problem & Solution	Identifies a problem and proposes solutions	Water scarcity and desalination solutions
Classification	Divides a broad subject into categories	Types of renewable energy sources

1.3 Structure of Expository Writing

Standard Structure

1. **Introduction** – Hook + Background + Thesis Statement
2. **Body Paragraphs** (usually 3+) – Each with a topic sentence, supporting evidence, and a concluding sentence
3. **Conclusion** – Restates thesis, summarizes key points, and provides a closing thought

2 Essay Writing

2.1 The Three-Part Structure

An essay is a short piece of writing on a particular subject. Every well-structured essay has three essential parts:

2.1.1 Introduction

The introduction is the gateway to your essay. It must accomplish three things:

Components of a Strong Introduction

1. **Hook (Attention Grabber)** – The very first sentence(s) designed to capture the reader's interest.
   - *Types of hooks:* A surprising fact/statistic, a provocative question, a vivid anecdote, a relevant quotation, a bold statement
2. **Background / Context** – 2–3 sentences that bridge the hook to the thesis by providing necessary context.
3. **Thesis Statement** – A single, clear, arguable sentence that states the main claim or focus of the essay. It is the *last sentence* of the introduction.

Formula for a Thesis Statement

Topic + Position/Claim + Reasons (optional blueprint) = Thesis

Example: "Social media *(topic)* has a detrimental impact on teenagers' mental health *(claim)* because it promotes unrealistic beauty standards, fosters cyberbullying, and reduces face-to-face social skills *(reasons)*."

2.1.2 Body Paragraphs

Each body paragraph develops **one** aspect of the thesis:

1. **Topic Sentence** – States the paragraph's main idea (connects to thesis).
2. **Explanation** – Clarifies what the topic sentence means.
3. **Evidence** – Facts, statistics, quotes, or examples that support the claim.
4. **Analysis** – Explains *how* the evidence supports the topic sentence.
5. **Transition** – Links to the next paragraph smoothly.

2.1.3 Conclusion

1. **Restate the thesis** (in different words – do not copy-paste).
2. **Summarize key points** from each body paragraph.
3. **Closing thought** – A call to action, a prediction, a broader implication, or a thought-provoking question.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

- Do NOT introduce **new** information in the conclusion.
- Do NOT start with "In this essay I will…" – show, don't announce.
- Do NOT use "I think / I feel" in expository/formal essays.

- Do NOT write a thesis that is a simple fact (not arguable).

2.2 Practice: Write the Introduction Only

Exercise 1 – Technology & Education

Topic: The impact of technology on modern education.
Task: Write a full introduction (hook + background + thesis).

Sample Introduction:
Hook: "In 2020, over 1.5 billion students worldwide were forced out of physical classrooms overnight—yet education did not stop."
Background: "The COVID-19 pandemic accelerated the adoption of digital tools in education, transforming laptops and smartphones into virtual classrooms. Online platforms such as Zoom and Google Classroom became household names within weeks."
Thesis: "While technology has expanded access to education and enabled flexible learning, it has also widened the digital divide, reduced meaningful student–teacher interaction, and raised concerns about academic integrity."

Exercise 2 – Social Media & Mental Health

Topic: Social media's effect on teenagers' mental health.
Task: Write a full introduction (hook + background + thesis).

Sample Introduction:
Hook: "A recent study by the American Psychological Association found that teenagers who spend more than three hours daily on social media are twice as likely to report symptoms of depression."
Background: "With platforms like Instagram, TikTok, and Snapchat dominating youth culture, the line between online personas and real-life identity has blurred considerably."
Thesis: "Excessive social media use negatively affects teenagers' mental health by fostering unrealistic self-comparisons, enabling cyberbullying, and disrupting healthy sleep patterns."

Exercise 3 – Climate Change

Topic: The urgency of addressing climate change.
Task: Write a full introduction.

Sample Introduction:
Hook: "The year 2023 was officially recorded as the hottest year in human history, shattering temperature records set just twelve months earlier."
Background: "Rising greenhouse gas emissions from industrialization, deforestation, and fossil fuel dependency continue to drive global temperatures upward, threatening ecosystems and human livelihoods."
Thesis: "Immediate and coordinated global action on climate change is essential because delayed responses will result in irreversible ecological damage, mass displacement of populations, and unsustainable economic losses."

Exercise 4 – Artificial Intelligence in Healthcare

Topic: The role of artificial intelligence in healthcare.
Task: Write a full introduction.

Sample Introduction:
Hook: "An AI system developed by Google Health detected breast cancer in mammograms with greater accuracy than six board-certified radiologists combined."
Background: "Artificial intelligence is rapidly integrating into the healthcare industry, from diagnostic imaging and drug discovery to robotic surgery and patient monitoring systems."
Thesis: "AI has the potential to revolutionize healthcare delivery by improving diagnostic accuracy, reducing medical errors, and making quality care more accessible—provided ethical and privacy concerns are adequately addressed."

Exercise 5 – Remote Work

Topic: The future of remote work.
Task: Write a full introduction.

Sample Introduction:
Hook: "A 2023 Stanford study revealed that employees working from home are 13% more productive than their office-based counterparts—yet 60% of CEOs want workers back at their desks."
Background: "The pandemic-era shift to remote work has permanently altered workplace norms, sparking an ongoing debate between employers seeking in-office collaboration and employees valuing flexibility and work-life balance."
Thesis: "A hybrid work model represents the most sustainable future of work because it balances organizational productivity with employee well-being, reduces overhead costs, and broadens the talent pool beyond geographic boundaries."

3 Report Writing

3.1 What is a Report?

A **report** is a structured document that presents information gathered through research, investigation, or analysis. Reports are written for a **specific audience** and **purpose**, and they typically include recommendations for action.

3.2 Formal vs. Informal Reports

Feature	Formal Report	Informal Report
Length	Long (10+ pages)	Short (1–5 pages)
Tone	Impersonal, objective, third person	May use first person; conversational
Structure	Title page, TOC, abstract, sections, appendices, references	Memo/letter format; headings optional
Purpose	Major decisions, stakeholders, external audiences	Internal updates, routine matters
Examples	Annual report, feasibility study, research report	Progress memo, trip report, incident summary

3.3 Standard Report Structure (What You Need to Practise)

Key Sections to Master

1. **Aims / Objectives** – What the report sets out to achieve or investigate.
2. **Methodology** – How data was collected (surveys, interviews, observation, experiments, literature review).
3. **Findings** – What the data/research revealed (presented with tables, charts, bullet points).
4. **Conclusions** – What the findings mean; interpretation and summary of key results.
5. **Recommendations** – Actionable suggestions based on the conclusions.

3.4 5 Practice Report-Writing Exercises

Report Exercise 1 – Student Attendance Analysis

Scenario: You are a student representative at a university. The dean has asked you to investigate why attendance has dropped by 25% this semester.

Aims/Objectives:

- To identify the primary causes of declining student attendance in Semester 6.
- To recommend strategies to improve attendance rates.

Methodology:

- Conducted an online survey of 200 students across 4 departments.
- Interviewed 10 faculty members to gather qualitative insights.
- Analysed attendance records from the university's LMS over the past two semesters.

Findings:

- 62% of students cited "boring lecture delivery" as a key reason.
- 45% said "early morning classes (8 AM)" clashed with commuting schedules.
- 30% preferred watching recorded lectures over attending in person.
- Departments with interactive teaching methods had 18% higher attendance.

Conclusions:

- The decline is primarily caused by unengaging teaching methods and inconvenient scheduling.
- The availability of recorded lectures has reduced the perceived necessity of physical attendance.

Recommendations:

- Introduce mandatory interactive components (quizzes, group discussions) that require physical presence.
- Reschedule critical courses to avoid 8 AM slots where possible.
- Provide faculty training workshops on engaging lecture delivery.
- Implement a blended attendance policy (e.g., 70% minimum in-person).

Report Exercise 2 – Workplace Safety Audit

Scenario: You are a safety officer at a manufacturing company. A recent incident prompted management to request a full safety audit.

Aims/Objectives:

- To assess current workplace safety conditions in the production facility.
- To identify hazards and recommend corrective measures.

Methodology:

- Physical inspection of all 3 production floors conducted over 5 days.
- Reviewed incident reports from the past 12 months (total: 47 incidents).
- Interviewed 30 workers and 5 supervisors using structured questionnaires.
- Compared findings against OSHA safety standards.

Findings:

- 60% of workers did not wear required PPE (personal protective equipment) consistently.
- Fire extinguishers on Floor 2 were expired (last inspected 18 months ago).
- Emergency exit signage was missing or obscured in 4 locations.
- 35% of incidents involved machinery with outdated safety guards.

Conclusions:

- The facility has significant non-compliance issues with PPE usage and equipment maintenance.
- The recent incident was not isolated; systemic safety gaps exist.

Recommendations:

- Enforce mandatory PPE checks before each shift with supervisor sign-off.
- Replace all expired fire extinguishers immediately and establish a quarterly in-

spection schedule.
- Install illuminated emergency exit signs in all identified locations within 2 weeks.
- Upgrade safety guards on all machinery and implement a preventive maintenance calendar.
- Conduct monthly safety drills and quarterly safety training sessions.

Report Exercise 3 – Customer Satisfaction Survey

Scenario: An e-commerce company has seen a 15% increase in product returns. You are tasked with investigating customer dissatisfaction.

Aims/Objectives:
- To determine the root causes of increasing product returns.
- To recommend improvements to product quality and customer experience.

Methodology:
- Analysed 1,200 return requests from Q1 2026 using the company's CRM system.
- Sent a post-return satisfaction survey to 500 customers (response rate: 68%).
- Conducted 15 phone interviews with repeat-return customers.
- Benchmarked return rates against industry averages.

Findings:
- 42% of returns were due to "product not matching description/photos."
- 28% cited "poor packaging leading to damage during delivery."
- 18% returned items due to "sizing inconsistencies" (clothing category).
- The company's return rate (12%) exceeds the industry average (8%).

Conclusions:
- Misleading product descriptions and inadequate packaging are the primary drivers.
- The lack of a standardized sizing chart contributes significantly to clothing returns.

Recommendations:
- Implement a product photography and description audit across all listings.
- Upgrade packaging materials, especially for fragile items, and add internal cushioning.
- Introduce a standardized sizing chart with detailed measurements for all clothing items.
- Add a "customer review photos" feature so buyers can see real-world product images.
- Set a target to reduce return rate to 8% within 6 months.

Report Exercise 4 – Campus Cafeteria Improvement

Scenario: The university administration has received multiple complaints about the campus cafeteria. You are a member of the student council asked to investigate and propose improvements.

Aims/Objectives:
- To evaluate the quality of food, hygiene standards, and pricing at the campus

cafeteria.
- To propose actionable improvement measures based on student feedback.

Methodology:
- Distributed a Google Forms survey to 350 students; received 280 responses.
- Conducted 3 unannounced hygiene inspections with a checklist (based on local food safety codes).
- Compared cafeteria prices with 5 eateries within a 1 km radius of campus.
- Held a focus group of 12 students to gather in-depth qualitative feedback.

Findings:
- 72% of respondents rated food quality as "below average" or "poor."
- During inspections, 2 out of 3 visits found uncovered food containers and unclean serving counters.
- Cafeteria prices were 20–30% higher than nearby alternatives for comparable items.
- Limited menu variety—only 4 main dishes available daily, with no vegetarian/vegan options.

Conclusions:
- The cafeteria's food quality, hygiene, and pricing are significantly below student expectations.
- The lack of dietary variety excludes a growing segment of students with specific dietary needs.

Recommendations:
- Renegotiate the vendor contract with mandatory quality and hygiene KPIs.
- Introduce a rotating weekly menu with at least 8 dishes daily, including vegetarian/vegan options.
- Cap pricing at no more than 10% above the average of nearby competitors.
- Install a student feedback kiosk at the cafeteria exit for real-time quality monitoring.
- Schedule monthly hygiene audits with results published on the student portal.

Report Exercise 5 – IT Infrastructure Upgrade Proposal

Scenario: A mid-sized company's IT systems are outdated, causing frequent downtime. The CTO has asked for a report evaluating the situation and recommending an upgrade path.

Aims/Objectives:
- To assess the current state of IT infrastructure and quantify downtime impact.
- To recommend a cost-effective upgrade plan with a clear timeline.

Methodology:
- Reviewed server logs and network monitoring data for the past 6 months.
- Conducted interviews with 8 department heads to understand productivity impact.
- Obtained quotes from 3 vendors for hardware and cloud migration services.
- Performed a cost-benefit analysis comparing on-premises upgrade vs. cloud migration.

Findings:

- The company experienced 47 hours of unplanned downtime in 6 months, costing an estimated $142,000 in lost productivity.
- 70% of servers are over 7 years old and no longer receive security patches.
- Current network bandwidth (100 Mbps) is insufficient for 150+ simultaneous users.
- Cloud migration would reduce infrastructure costs by 35% over 3 years compared to an on-premises hardware refresh.

Conclusions:

- The IT infrastructure is critically outdated and poses both security and productivity risks.
- Cloud migration offers a more scalable, cost-effective, and secure solution than on-premises upgrades.

Recommendations:

- Migrate core services (email, file storage, CRM) to a cloud provider (e.g., AWS/Azure) within Q3 2026.
- Upgrade network switches and increase bandwidth to 1 Gbps.
- Decommission servers older than 5 years and implement a 4-year hardware refresh cycle.
- Allocate a budget of $180,000 for Phase 1 (cloud migration + network upgrade).
- Hire a dedicated cloud administrator or upskill existing IT staff through certifications.

4 Plagiarism

Definition

Plagiarism is the act of using someone else's words, ideas, or work and presenting them as your own—whether intentionally or unintentionally—without proper acknowledgment.

4.1 Types of Plagiarism

1. Direct Plagiarism

What it is: Copying someone's exact words **word-for-word** without quotation marks or attribution.

Example:

- **Original (by author X):** "Climate change is the defining crisis of our time, demanding immediate global cooperation."
- **Plagiarised version:** "Climate change is the defining crisis of our time, demanding immediate global cooperation." *(no citation, no quotation marks)*

How to avoid: Use quotation marks and cite the source, OR paraphrase in your own words with a citation.

2. Mosaic (Patchwork) Plagiarism

What it is: Taking phrases from a source and mixing them into your own writing **without quotation marks**, changing only a few words to disguise the borrowing. The patchwork of original and borrowed text makes it seem original.

Example:

- **Original:** "The rapid deforestation of the Amazon is accelerating biodiversity loss at an alarming rate."
- **Mosaic version:** "The fast deforestation of the Amazon is speeding up the loss of biodiversity at a concerning pace." *(synonyms swapped, structure kept)*

How to avoid: Fully paraphrase by restructuring the sentence *and* using your own vocabulary, then cite. If you keep any original phrasing, use quotation marks.

3. Self-Plagiarism

What it is: Reusing your own previously submitted work (or portions of it) for a new assignment **without disclosure**.

Example:

- Submitting an essay you wrote last semester for a different course as if it were new work.
- Copy-pasting your methodology section from a previous report into a new one.

How to avoid: Always write fresh content for each assignment. If reuse is necessary, get permission from the instructor and cite your previous work.

4. Accidental Plagiarism

What it is: Unintentionally failing to cite a source, misquoting, or poorly paraphrasing—not out of dishonesty, but out of carelessness or ignorance.

Common causes:

- Forgetting to note down a source during research.
- Not knowing the correct citation format (APA, MLA, etc.).
- Paraphrasing too closely to the original without realising.

How to avoid:

- Take detailed notes with full source information during research.
- Learn the required citation style and follow it consistently.
- Use plagiarism-checking tools (Turnitin, Grammarly) before submission.
- **When in doubt, cite.**

Quick Reference: How to Avoid All Plagiarism

1. **Cite** all sources—direct quotes, paraphrases, and ideas.
2. **Paraphrase** properly: change both words **and** sentence structure.
3. **Use quotation marks** for any directly copied phrases.
4. **Keep a bibliography** as you research.
5. **Run plagiarism checkers** before final submission.

5 7 C's of Communication

Overview

The 7 C's provide a **checklist** for making sure that your meetings, emails, conference calls, reports, and presentations are well constructed and clear—so your audience gets your message. They apply to **both written and oral communication**.

5.1 The 7 C's – Detailed Breakdown

1. Completeness – Convey ALL Required Facts

- The message must include **all** information the audience needs to understand and act.
- Answers all of the receiver's questions – leaves no gaps.
- Adds additional information wherever required.
- Helps the audience make **better decisions** because they have all desired and crucial information.
- A complete communication builds and enhances the **reputation** of an organization.
- Cost-saving: no additional messages needed to fill in missing details.

Ask yourself: *Who? What? When? Where? Why? How?* – if any answer is missing, add it.

2. Conciseness – Say It in the Fewest Possible Words

- Communicate what you want in the **least possible words** without sacrificing the other C's.
- It is both **time-saving** and **cost-saving**.
- Highlights the **main message** by avoiding excessive and needless words.
- A concise message is **non-repetitive** in nature.
- A short, essential message is more **appealing and comprehensible** to the audience.

Rule of thumb: *If a word is not doing work, delete it.*

3. Consideration – Step Into the Receiver's Shoes

- Take the audience's **viewpoints, background, mindset, education level** into account.
- Emphasise the **"you" approach** – focus on the receiver, not just the sender.
- Show **empathy** and genuine interest in the audience. This stimulates a positive reaction.
- Show **optimism**: emphasise "what is possible" rather than "what is impossible."
- Use **positive words**: jovial, committed, thanks, warm, healthy, help.
- Ensure the **self-respect** of the audience is maintained and emotions are not harmed.

4. Clarity – One Message at a Time

- Emphasise on a **specific message or goal at a time**, rather than trying to achieve too much at once.
- Use **exact, appropriate, and concrete words** – avoid vague or ambiguous language.
- Makes **understanding easier** for the receiver.
- Complete clarity of thoughts and ideas **enhances the meaning** of the message.
- The purpose of the communication should be **clear to the sender first** – only then will the receiver understand.

Test: *Can this sentence be misunderstood? If yes, rewrite it.*

5. Concreteness – Be Specific and Definite

- Be **particular and clear** rather than fuzzy and general.
- Support your message with **specific facts and figures**.
- Concrete messages are **not misinterpreted** – there is no room for misunderstanding.
- Builds **confidence and reputation** of the sender.
- Uses words that are clear and that build credibility.

Example: *"Sales increased"* → *"Sales increased by 15% in Q3 2025."*

6. Courtesy – Be Polite and Respectful

- The message should show the sender's **sincerity** and **respect** the receiver.
- The sender should be **polite, judicious, reflective, and enthusiastic**.
- Take into consideration **both viewpoints and feelings** of the receiver.
- The message should be **positive and audience-focused**.
- It must **not be biased** and must use terms showing respect for the receiver.

7. Correctness – No Errors; Accurate and Well-Timed

- There should be **no grammatical or spelling errors** in the communication.
- The message must be **exact, correct, and well-timed**.
- Check for **precision and accuracy** of all facts and figures.
- Use **appropriate and correct language** for the audience's level.
- A correct message **boosts confidence** and has **greater impact** on the audience.

Memory Aid

Complete → **C**oncise → **C**onsiderate → **C**lear → **C**oncrete → **C**ourteous → **C**orrect

Think: "**C**ommunication that is **C**omplete, **C**oncise, **C**onsiderate, **C**lear, **C**oncrete, **C**ourteous, and **C**orrect will always **C**onnect with the audience."

6 100 Ways to Improve Your Writing – Key Takeaways

*Based on the book by **Gary Provost**. The book has 11 major chapters with 100 tips total. Below is a distilled summary of the **most exam-relevant** principles – the minimum you need to remember.*

6.1 Part I: Improve Your Writing When You're Not Writing (9 Tips)

Core Ideas

1. **Get reference books:** Dictionary, thesaurus, encyclopedia—keep them at arm's length.
2. **Expand vocabulary:** Use the words you already know more deliberately; don't chase obscure words.
3. **Improve spelling:** Use spell check but know its limits (e.g., *there/their/they're*).
4. **Read widely:** Novels, news, magazines—observe how good writers structure their work.
5. **Take a class:** A good teacher with publishing experience beats a pretentious one.
6. **Eavesdrop:** Listen to real conversations for natural dialogue and slang.
7. **Research thoroughly:** Look it up, ask somebody, observe it, ask a librarian.
8. **Write in your head:** Plan your opening and structure before sitting down.
9. **Choose a time & place:** Write in long uninterrupted blocks, in a quiet environment.

6.2 Part II: Overcome Writer's Block (9 Tips)

Key Strategies

- **Copy a passage** you admire word-for-word to internalise good style.
- **Keep a journal** – it exercises your writing muscles daily.
- **Talk about your writing** to plug into others' knowledge.
- **Do warm-up exercises** (describe something random; list rhyming words).
- **Organize material** before writing, but leave room for creativity.
- **Make a list** of key elements, even a short one.
- **Picture your reader** – adjust vocabulary and tone to your audience.
- **Know WHY you're writing** – purpose determines word choice and structure.

6.3 Part III: Write a Strong Beginning (5 Tips)

Strong Beginnings

1. **Find a slant:** Don't try to cover everything. Pick one manageable aspect.
2. **Write a strong lead:** Provocative, energetic, creating curiosity. Give readers something to *care about* before drowning them in background.
3. **Don't make empty promises:** Your lead must deliver on what it implies.

4. **Set a tone and maintain it:** Don't jar the reader by switching between urgent and leisurely.
5. **Begin at the beginning:** Cut "warm-up" writing. Your first sentence should do real work.

6.4 Part IV: Save Time & Energy (9 Tips)

- **Pyramid construction:** Put the most important info first (who, what, when, where, why).
- **Topic sentences:** The first sentence of each paragraph states its main idea.
- **Short paragraphs** are faster, livelier, and clearer.
- **Transitional phrases:** Bridge the reader smoothly between sections (e.g., "On the other hand," "Twenty years later").
- **Don't over-explain** transitions – "Sam drove to the church" is enough.
- **Bridge words:** Repeat a key word from one paragraph in the next to show logical connection.
- **Avoid wordiness:** "It is my objective to utilize" → "I want to use."
- **Steal small:** Borrow a metaphor or anecdote (with credit), not whole passages.
- **Stop at the end:** Don't linger. If the last sentence can be cut without loss, cut it.

6.5 Part V: Develop Style (10 Tips)

Style Essentials

- **Style = form, not content.** Same info, different arrangement = different impact.
- **Listen to your writing:** Read it aloud. Writing is music.
- **Mimic spoken language:** Sound conversational but exploit the advantages of revision.
- **Vary sentence length:** Short. Medium. And sometimes long. *Write music.*
- **Vary sentence construction:** Don't start every sentence with subject-verb-object.
- **Show, don't tell:** "She ran 5 miles in a storm to see me" > "She's very athletic."
- **Keep related words together:** Place adjectives near the nouns they modify.
- **Use parallel construction:** "Fish gotta swim, birds gotta fly" (not "flying is something birds do").
- **Don't force a personal style:** Write well; style will emerge naturally.

6.6 Part VI: Give Words Power (12 Tips)

Power Words

- Use **short words** ("stop" > "discontinue").
- Use **dense words** ("monthly" > "once a month").
- Use **familiar words** ("jaw" > "mandible").
- Use **active verbs** ("towered" > "was").
- Use **strong verbs** ("paced" instead of "walked nervously").

- Use **specific nouns** ("bulldog" > "dog"; "priest" > "man").
- Use **active voice** most of the time ("John broke the vase" > "The vase was broken by John").
- **Say things positively** ("the safe was open" > "the safe was not closed").
- **Be specific** ("On March 5 my father died" > "Recently there was a death in my family").
- Use **statistics** sparingly – "sprinkle like pepper, not smeared like butter."
- **Provide facts** – concrete data is more persuasive than vague conclusions.
- Put **emphatic words at the end** of the sentence for maximum impact.

6.7 Part VII: Make People Like Your Writing (11 Tips)

- **Be likable:** Write clearly, conversationally; present an honest picture of yourself.
- **Write about people:** Readers care about humans, not abstract systems.
- **Show your opinion** (but include other viewpoints too).
- **Obey your own rules:** The tone/scope set in the intro is a contract with the reader.
- **Use anecdotes:** Short stories that make a point are powerful reader-pleasers.
- **Use examples:** Back up generalizations with specific instances.
- **Name your sources:** Credibility depends on who said it.
- **Provide useful information** (dates, addresses, actionable steps).
- **Use quotations** for poetic reinforcement and credibility by association.
- **Use quotes** from interviews—trim them to the essential words.
- **Create a strong title:** Short, curious, revealing, and slanted.

6.8 Part VIII–IX: Grammar & Punctuation (16 Tips)

Grammar Essentials

- **Respect grammar rules** – they are the currency of communication.
- **Don't change tenses** within a passage.
- **Possessives:** Add **'s** for singular (*dog's*); add **'** for plural ending in s (*dogs'*). **its** (possessive) vs. **it's** (it is).
- **Subject-verb agreement:** "The list of actors *is*" (not *are*).
- **Fix dangling modifiers:** "In drawing the picture, *he* used his wife as a model" (not "his wife was used").
- **Don't split infinitives** unless clarity demands it.
- **Comma rules:** Use for nonrestrictive clauses, series, introductory words, direct quotes.
- **Semicolons:** Join closely related independent clauses without a conjunction.
- **Colons:** Introduce lists, formal quotations, examples.
- **Quotation marks:** Only for directly quoted speech/writing and words being defined.
- **Prefer good writing to good grammar** – "I ain't got no money" can be great writing in context.

6.9 Part X–XI: Reader Relations & Self-Editing (19 Tips)

- **Avoid jargon:** "Don't walk for 6 weeks" > "Remain un-ambulatory."

- **Avoid clichés:** They make writing feel lazy and unoriginal.
- **Avoid parentheses and footnotes:** They interrupt the reader's flow.
- **Don't play the mystery game:** Don't withhold key information to "surprise" the reader at the end.
- **Don't cheat:** Be honest; don't obscure quotes or ignore opposing facts.
- **Read your work aloud:** You'll hear errors your eyes miss.
- **Cut unnecessary words:** "The annual ball is held once a year in Quincy" → "The annual ball is held in Quincy."
- **Let a draft rest:** Wait at least a day before final revision.
- **Ask 13 self-editing questions:** Is it clear? Does each paragraph advance the subject? Are there grammar/punctuation errors? (See the full list in Chapter 11.)

Gary Provost's Most Famous Passage (Varying Sentence Length)

"This sentence has five words. Here are five more words. Five-word sentences are fine. But several together become monotonous. Listen to what is happening. The writing is getting boring. The sound of it drones. It's like a stuck record. The ear demands some variety. Now listen. I vary the sentence length, and I create music. Music. The writing sings."

7 Reading Comprehension

What is Reading Comprehension?

Reading comprehension is the ability to **read text, process it, and understand its meaning**. It involves:

- Decoding the words
- Understanding vocabulary in context
- Identifying the main idea and supporting details
- Making inferences (reading "between the lines")
- Evaluating the author's purpose, tone, and bias

7.1 Strategies for Reading Comprehension

1. **Preview the text:** Read the title, headings, and first/last paragraphs before reading the full text.
2. **Identify the main idea:** Ask "What is this passage mostly about?" after each paragraph.
3. **Look for signal words:** *However, therefore, for example, in contrast, moreover* – these reveal text structure.
4. **Ask questions as you read:** Who? What? When? Where? Why? How?
5. **Summarise each paragraph** in one sentence in your own words.
6. **Make inferences:** Combine clues from the text with your own knowledge.
7. **Re-read difficult parts:** Slow down for complex sentences; don't skip.

7.2 Reading Comprehension Practice Exercises

Exercise 1 – Science Passage

Read the passage and answer the questions:
"The water cycle, also known as the hydrological cycle, describes the continuous movement of water on, above, and below the surface of the Earth. Water evaporates from oceans, lakes, and rivers due to heat energy from the sun. As water vapour rises, it cools and condenses into tiny droplets that form clouds. When these droplets combine and grow heavy enough, they fall back to Earth as precipitation—rain, snow, sleet, or hail. Some of this water flows into rivers and streams (runoff), some seeps into the ground (infiltration) and replenishes aquifers, and some is taken up by plants (transpiration). Eventually, through evaporation and transpiration, water returns to the atmosphere, completing the cycle."

Questions:

1. What is the main topic of the passage?
2. What causes water to evaporate from oceans?
3. What happens when water vapour rises and cools?
4. Name three things that can happen to water after precipitation.
5. What does the word "infiltration" mean in this context?

Answers:

1. The water cycle / hydrological cycle
2. Heat energy from the sun
3. It condenses into tiny droplets that form clouds
4. Runoff (flows into rivers), infiltration (seeps into ground), transpiration (taken up by plants)
5. Water seeping into the ground

Exercise 2 – Social Issue Passage

Read the passage and answer the questions:

"Urbanisation is one of the defining trends of the 21st century. By 2050, nearly 70% of the world's population is expected to live in cities. While urban areas offer better healthcare, education, and employment opportunities, rapid and unplanned urbanisation can lead to overcrowding, pollution, inadequate housing, and strain on public services. Developing countries face the greatest challenges, as their cities are growing faster than infrastructure can be built. Governments must invest in sustainable urban planning, including public transportation, green spaces, and affordable housing, to ensure cities remain liveable."

Questions:

1. What percentage of the world's population is expected to live in cities by 2050?
2. List two advantages of living in urban areas mentioned in the passage.
3. What problems can unplanned urbanisation cause?
4. Which countries face the greatest urbanisation challenges, and why?
5. What is the author's main recommendation?

Answers:

1. Nearly 70%
2. Better healthcare, education, and employment opportunities (any two)
3. Overcrowding, pollution, inadequate housing, strain on public services
4. Developing countries – their cities grow faster than infrastructure can be built
5. Invest in sustainable urban planning (public transport, green spaces, affordable housing)

Exercise 3 – Technology Passage

Read the passage and answer the questions:

"Artificial intelligence has transformed how businesses operate across nearly every industry. In healthcare, AI algorithms can analyse medical images with greater accuracy than many specialists, enabling earlier detection of diseases such as cancer. In finance, AI-powered systems detect fraudulent transactions in real time, saving institutions billions annually. However, the rise of AI has also raised ethical concerns. Critics argue that automated decision-making can perpetuate biases present in training data, and that increased automation threatens to displace millions of workers. Proponents counter that AI will create new categories of jobs and free humans from repetitive tasks, allowing them to focus on creative and strategic work."

Questions:

1. According to the passage, how does AI help in healthcare?
2. What ethical concern about AI is mentioned?

3. What do AI proponents argue as benefits?
4. What does "perpetuate" most likely mean in context?
5. Is the passage's tone supportive, critical, or balanced? How do you know?

Answers:

1. AI analyses medical images with greater accuracy, enabling earlier disease detection
2. AI can perpetuate biases in training data; automation may displace workers
3. AI will create new job categories and free humans from repetitive tasks
4. To continue/maintain (in this case, continue biases)
5. Balanced – the passage presents both advantages (healthcare, fraud detection) and concerns (bias, job loss)

Exercise 4 – Historical Passage

Read the passage and answer the questions:

"The printing press, invented by Johannes Gutenberg around 1440, is widely considered one of the most important inventions in human history. Before its creation, books were laboriously copied by hand, making them extremely expensive and accessible only to the wealthy and the clergy. Gutenberg's movable-type press made it possible to produce books quickly and cheaply, dramatically increasing literacy rates across Europe. The printing press also played a crucial role in the Protestant Reformation, as Martin Luther's ideas could be rapidly disseminated through printed pamphlets. Within 50 years of its invention, an estimated 20 million volumes had been printed in Europe."

Questions:

1. When and by whom was the printing press invented?
2. How were books produced before the printing press?
3. What effect did the printing press have on literacy?
4. How did the printing press contribute to the Protestant Reformation?
5. What does "disseminated" mean in context?

Answers:

1. Around 1440, by Johannes Gutenberg
2. Books were copied by hand, making them expensive and limited to the wealthy/clergy
3. It dramatically increased literacy rates across Europe
4. Luther's ideas could be rapidly spread through printed pamphlets
5. Distributed/spread widely

Exercise 5 – Environmental Passage

Read the passage and answer the questions:

"Plastic pollution has emerged as one of the most pressing environmental crises of our time. Approximately 8 million metric tons of plastic waste enters the world's oceans every year, according to a study published in the journal Science. Marine animals mistake plastic debris for food, leading to internal injuries, starvation, and death. Microplastics—tiny fragments less than 5mm in size—have been found in drinking water, seafood, and even human blood. While recycling is often promoted as a solution, only about 9% of all plastic ever produced has been recycled. Experts advocate for a multi-pronged approach: reducing single-use plastics, improving waste management

infrastructure in developing countries, and investing in biodegradable alternatives."

Questions:

1. How much plastic enters the oceans annually?
2. What are microplastics, and where have they been found?
3. Why is recycling alone insufficient as a solution?
4. What three-part solution do experts recommend?
5. What is the author's purpose in writing this passage?

Answers:

1. Approximately 8 million metric tons per year
2. Tiny plastic fragments <5mm; found in drinking water, seafood, and human blood
3. Only about 9% of all plastic ever produced has been recycled
4. Reduce single-use plastics, improve waste management in developing countries, invest in biodegradable alternatives
5. To inform readers about the severity of plastic pollution and advocate for comprehensive solutions

8 Skimming Exercises

What is Skimming?

Skimming is a reading technique used to quickly identify the **main idea** or **gist** of a text **without reading every word**. It involves:

- Reading titles, headings, and subheadings
- Reading the **first and last sentences** of each paragraph
- Glancing at bold, italicised, or highlighted text
- Looking at images, charts, and captions
- Skipping details, examples, and supporting data

Goal: Get the overall picture in 20–30% of normal reading time.
When to use: Previewing a chapter, reviewing before an exam, deciding if a source is relevant.

8.1 Skimming vs. Scanning

Feature	Skimming	Scanning
Purpose	Get the main idea / overview	Find a specific piece of information
Speed	Fast (20–30% of reading time)	Very fast (looking for a keyword)
Focus	General understanding	Specific data (date, name, number)
Eye movement	Sweeps across text	Jumps around text
Example	"What is this article about?"	"What year was the company founded?"

8.2 Skimming Practice Exercises

Skimming Exercise 1

Instructions: You have **60 seconds** to skim the following passage. Then answer the question **without looking back**.

"Electric vehicles (EVs) are becoming increasingly popular as governments around the world push for greener transportation. In 2023, global EV sales exceeded 14 million units, a 35% increase from the previous year. Major automakers like Tesla, BYD, and Volkswagen are investing billions in battery technology to extend driving range and reduce charging times. Despite this growth, challenges remain. Charging infrastructure in rural areas is still limited, battery production depends on mining lithium and cobalt—processes that carry their own environmental costs—and the initial purchase price of EVs remains higher than that of comparable gasoline-powered cars. Analysts predict that by 2030, EVs will account for over 40% of all new car sales worldwide."

After skimming, answer:

1. What is this passage mainly about?
2. Is the overall tone optimistic, pessimistic, or balanced?

Expected Answers:
1. The growth and challenges of electric vehicles
2. Balanced (mentions both growth and challenges)

Skimming Exercise 2

Instructions: Skim in **45 seconds**. Answer without looking back.
"Sleep deprivation among university students is a growing concern. Studies indicate that over 60% of college students do not get the recommended 7–9 hours of sleep per night. The consequences are severe: impaired memory consolidation, reduced cognitive function, weakened immune response, and increased susceptibility to anxiety and depression. Late-night study sessions, excessive screen time, and irregular sleep schedules are the primary culprits. Sleep researchers recommend maintaining a consistent bedtime, limiting caffeine after 2 PM, and creating a dark, cool sleeping environment. Universities are also beginning to offer 'sleep hygiene' workshops to combat this epidemic."
After skimming, answer:
1. What is the main problem discussed?
2. Who is the target audience for this text?

Expected Answers:
1. Sleep deprivation among university students
2. University students (and possibly university administrators)

Skimming Exercise 3

Instructions: Skim in **60 seconds**. Answer without looking back.
"The freelance economy, sometimes called the 'gig economy,' has expanded rapidly over the past decade. Platforms like Upwork, Fiverr, and Toptal connect millions of freelancers with clients worldwide. For workers, freelancing offers flexibility, autonomy, and the opportunity to work from anywhere. However, it also comes with significant drawbacks: no employer-provided health insurance, no retirement benefits, income instability, and the constant need to market oneself. A McKinsey report estimates that 36% of the US workforce now engages in some form of independent work. Governments are grappling with how to regulate this sector, with some countries introducing portable benefits systems that follow workers across multiple gigs."
After skimming, answer:
1. What is the passage about?
2. Name one advantage and one disadvantage of freelancing mentioned.

Expected Answers:
1. The growth, benefits, and challenges of the freelance/gig economy
2. Advantage: flexibility/autonomy/work from anywhere. Disadvantage: no insurance/unstable income/no retirement benefits

Skimming Exercise 4

Instructions: Skim in **45 seconds**. Answer without looking back.
"Renewable energy sources—solar, wind, hydroelectric, and geothermal—now account for nearly 30% of global electricity generation. Solar power has seen the most dramatic

cost reduction, falling by 89% over the past decade. China leads the world in renewable energy capacity, followed by the United States and India. Despite this progress, fossil fuels still dominate the global energy mix, accounting for approximately 80% of total primary energy consumption. The transition to renewables faces obstacles including energy storage limitations, grid infrastructure modernization, and political resistance from fossil fuel-dependent economies."

After skimming, answer:

1. What percentage of global electricity comes from renewables?
2. What is the main obstacle to the energy transition?

Expected Answers:

1. Nearly 30%
2. Energy storage, grid modernization, and political resistance (any one)

Skimming Exercise 5

Instructions: Skim in **60 seconds**. Answer without looking back.

"Water scarcity affects more than 2 billion people in the world today. By 2025, two-thirds of the global population could be living under water-stressed conditions. Agriculture consumes approximately 70% of the world's freshwater supply, making it the largest user by far. Climate change is worsening the crisis by altering rainfall patterns and accelerating glacier melt. Innovative solutions are emerging: desalination plants in the Middle East, rainwater harvesting systems in India, and drip irrigation in Israel have all shown promise. However, experts emphasize that conservation—reducing waste in homes, industries, and farms—remains the most cost-effective strategy. International cooperation is essential, particularly for managing shared river basins that cross national borders."

After skimming, answer:

1. What is the largest consumer of freshwater?
2. What does the passage argue is the most cost-effective strategy?

Expected Answers:

1. Agriculture (approximately 70%)
2. Conservation (reducing waste)

9 Quick Revision Cheat Sheet

One-Page Exam Recap

Expository Writing: Explains/informs; objective; thesis-driven; 6 types (Descriptive, Process, Compare/Contrast, Cause/Effect, Problem/Solution, Classification).

Essay Structure:

- **Introduction:** Hook → Background → Thesis (last sentence)
- **Body:** Topic sentence → Evidence → Analysis → Transition
- **Conclusion:** Restate thesis → Summarise → Closing thought

Report Sections: Aims → Methodology → Findings → Conclusions → Recommendations

Plagiarism Types: Direct (word-for-word), Mosaic (patchwork synonyms), Self (reusing own work), Accidental (careless omission).

7 C's: Completeness, Conciseness, Consideration, Clarity, Concreteness, Courtesy, Correctness.

100 Ways – Top 10 Rules:

1. Vary sentence length – write music, not monotone.
2. Show, don't tell.
3. Use active voice and strong verbs.
4. Use specific nouns (bulldog > dog).
5. Write a strong lead – hook the reader in the first sentence.
6. Avoid wordiness – cut unnecessary words.
7. Read your work aloud.
8. Know your audience (picture a reader).
9. Use pyramid construction (most important info first).
10. Use parallel construction for rhythm and clarity.

Skimming: Read titles, first/last sentences, bold text. Get the gist fast.
Scanning: Search for specific info (name, date, number).
Comprehension: Identify main idea, infer meaning, evaluate tone/purpose.

Good luck with your exam!

"Good writing is clear thinking made visible." — Bill Wheeler